DEVELOPER PLAYBOOK · NO UPWORK · NO FIVERR

Top 10 Freelance Platforms & Intern → Junior Path

A practical guide for developers with internship experience who need paid work, public proof, and a real title change — without bidding against seniors with hundreds of five-star reviews.

WHO THIS IS FOR
Interns and junior-bound full-stack developers (.NET, Laravel, React, Next.js, Jetpack Compose)

GOAL
Earn early income, ship real portfolio work, and list yourself as Freelance / Junior Developer

NOT INCLUDED
Upwork and Fiverr — high-review bidding markets that stall beginners

READ THE BADGES
Start here · Good fit · Later · Senior-only · Inactive

Organized from your research notes, with intern-fit labels and current platform status (Replit Bounties closed; BountySource defunct; Huntr OSS program sunset). Never pay to get hired.

Contents

1. **How to use this guide** — intern-to-junior reality check
2. **Top 10 platforms (not Upwork / Fiverr)**
3. **Best platforms for former interns**
4. **Practical seniority strategy**
5. **GitHub bounties beyond Algora**
6. **Where you should try first**
7. **Microsoft, Discord, and other OSS bounties**
8. **VS Code, Telegram, GitHub Apps**
9. **Other ecosystems (CMS, Chrome, Linux, APIs, AI)**
10. **Stack-specific start (.NET / Laravel / React / Compose)**
11. **Do you pay? Is there an interview?**
12. **Beginner prices**
13. **Are these legit if they are not as famous as Upwork?**
14. **Day-1 checklist & scam red flags**

> **The intern problem in one sentence**
>
> Breaking in as a developer with only internships is hard on major bidding sites because you compete against senior engineers with hundreds of reviews. The fix is not a better Upwork proposal. It is curated gigs, paid GitHub issues, micro-services with a tight scope, and converting internships into junior proof.

1. How to use this guide

Use the color badges on every platform:

- START HERE Realistic this month with internship-only experience
- GOOD FIT Useful once you have 1–3 public samples or reviews
- LATER Fine to set up a profile, but do not wait here for clients
- SENIOR ONLY Screening is built for proven seniors — skip until you have production years
- INACTIVE Closed, bankrupt, or pivoted — do not plan income here

> **Do not apply to Toptal, Braintrust, or Arc.dev first**
>
> They are excellent networks — for people companies already pay $80–$150/hr. They will not bridge intern → junior. Your first wins come from micro-tasks, bounties, local clients, and contract filters on Wellfound / Contra.

2. Top 10 freelance platforms (not Upwork or Fiverr)

Vetted & high-end networks

1. Toptal SENIOR ONLY

BEST FOR	Senior developers, financial experts, product managers, and designers
HOW IT WORKS	Rigorously screens applicants and accepts only the top 3% of talent. There is no public bidding. Toptal manually matches you with high-budget clients (often Fortune 500 companies and funded startups).
FEES	0% fee for freelancers (Toptal charges clients a markup)
INTERN NOTE	Do not spend weeks on the screening. Come back after you have shipped paid client work and can pass live coding + English interviews.

2. Braintrust SENIOR ONLY

BEST FOR	Tech professionals, software engineers, and product strategists
HOW IT WORKS	A decentralized, user-owned network that matches tech talent with enterprise clients such as NASA, Nestlé, and Deloitte.
FEES	0% platform fee for freelancers (clients pay a flat 10% fee)
INTERN NOTE	Enterprise buyers expect mid/senior resumes. Create a profile later; do not wait for matches.

Commission-free & modern alternatives

3. Contra START HERE

BEST FOR	Digital nomads, designers, writers, and tech independents building a brand portfolio
HOW IT WORKS	Hybrid of portfolio showcase and marketplace. Clients can discover your profile and hire you, or you send commission-free invoices to existing clients.
FEES	0% commission on earnings (optional ~$29/mo Pro features)
INTERN NOTE	Best used as a clean public shop window for 2–3 micro-services, not as a place you wait for inbound leads. Replit pointed former Bounties users here after shutting down.
URL	contra.com

4. Hubstaff Talent GOOD FIT

BEST FOR	Developers, marketers, and virtual assistants looking for ongoing remote roles
HOW IT WORKS	A transparent directory. You post a profile and hourly rate. Clients contact you directly — no bidding, no middleman.
FEES	100% free for freelancers and clients (supported by Hubstaff's time-tracking product)
INTERN NOTE	Fill rate, stack, and a live GitHub/demo. Set $15–$25/hr. Check weekly; do not refresh all day.
URL	talent.hubstaff.com

Traditional general marketplaces

5. Freelancer.com LATER

BEST FOR	Generalists across software, writing, design, and data entry who want high volume of global listings
HOW IT WORKS	The closest direct equivalent to Upwork's bidding model. Clients post jobs; freelancers submit proposals and bids.
FEES	10% or $5 (whichever is higher) for fixed-price; 10% for hourly
INTERN NOTE	Same trap as Upwork: volume + bid wars. If you use it, only bid on tiny, specific bugfix jobs — never "build my full app."

6. Guru GOOD FIT

BEST FOR	Long-term contracts, technical projects, and small agencies
HOW IT WORKS	Flexible terms (hourly, fixed-price, recurring, milestones) plus digital Workrooms for project management.
FEES	5% to 9% depending on membership tier
INTERN NOTE	Less crowded than Upwork. Profile + 3 samples still matter more than the number of bids you send.
URL	guru.com

7. PeoplePerHour START HERE

BEST FOR	European and UK-based work in web development, design, and content
HOW IT WORKS	Mix of proposal bidding and pre-packaged fixed-price bundles called Hourlies.
FEES	3.5% to 20% (tiered by lifetime earnings per client; drops to 3.5% for repeat clients)
INTERN NOTE	Hourlies are the intern-friendly path: “I will add a Laravel/ASP.NET endpoint,” not open bidding. Stronger for EU time zones than US platforms.
URL	peopleperhour.com

Specialist & niche platforms

8. Arc.dev SENIOR ONLY

BEST FOR	Senior software developers seeking full-time remote or long-term contract roles
HOW IT WORKS	Tech-only. After video and technical coding assessments, Arc pitches your profile to companies.
FEES	0% fee for developers
INTERN NOTE	Assessments assume job-ready seniors. Skip until you have a junior title plus public PRs.

9. 99designs LATER DESIGNERS

BEST FOR	Graphic designers, illustrators, brand strategists, and UI/UX specialists
HOW IT WORKS	Client design contests (winner selected) or direct 1-on-1 project contracts
FEES	15%–20% project fee by designer level, plus a $100 introduction fee spread across the first $500 with a new client
INTERN NOTE	Not a developer marketplace. Only useful if you sell UI/brand work, not APIs.

10. Wellfound (formerly AngelList Talent) START HERE

BEST FOR	Developers, startup growth marketers, and product people who want early-stage to growth startups
HOW IT WORKS	Direct network, not a gig bidding site. You apply to companies with an hourly contract rate or contract-to-hire preference.
FEES	0% fee for freelancers (companies pay for recruiting tools)
INTERN NOTE	Filter Contract / Part-time / Freelance. Early startups often cannot pay $120/hr seniors and will take a hungry intern-level contractor for 10–20 hours/week.
URL	wellfound.com

#	Platform	Fee (you)	Intern → junior?	Use it for
1	Toptal	0%	No — senior screening	Ignore until mid-level
2	Braintrust	0%	No — enterprise talent	Ignore until mid-level
3	Contra	0%	Yes — portfolio + invoices	3 packaged micro-services
4	Hubstaff Talent	0%	Yes — free directory	Profile + $15–$25/hr
5	Freelancer.com	10% / $5	Weak — same as Upwork	Tiny bug tickets only
6	Guru	5–9%	Maybe — less crowded	Longer technical jobs
7	PeoplePerHour	3.5–20%	Yes — Hourlies	EU/UK fixed bundles
8	Arc.dev	0%	No — senior tech	Ignore until junior+
9	99designs	15–20%	No — design contests	Skip unless you design
10	Wellfound	0%	Yes — contract filter	Startup 10–20h/week gigs

3. Best freelance & contract platforms for former interns

To bridge intern → junior, earn early income, and build real portfolio projects, target curated gig sites, open-source micro-tasks, and specialist hubs — not $5,000 full-stack contests.

1. Codementor LATER NEEDS SPOKEN ENGLISH

Why it fits: Instead of competing for massive $5,000 full-stack builds, you offer live 1-on-1 video help, code reviews, and bug fixes for beginners or non-technical founders.

Why it builds seniority: Explaining code, debugging someone else's repository, and refactoring PRs shows mid-level engineering better than tutorial projects.

Earnings: $15–$30+ per 15-minute session to start.

Honest catch: Sessions are live video. If spoken English is still around B1, skip this until B2. Written bounties and Hourlies are a better first step.

2. Codeur (and similar local EU boards) GOOD FIT

Why it fits: Entry-level developers struggle to find whole clients. Boards like Codeur (France) and other European contract sites list bite-sized maintenance: fix a CSS grid, add an API endpoint, run a database migration.

Why it builds seniority: You work inside existing codebases — the core junior-developer expectation.

Note: Codeable is *not* a beginner network. It is a vetted WordPress expert marketplace. Do not apply to Codeable with internship-only experience. Use Codeur / local boards / GitHub issues instead. Microverse is a paid school, not a gig board.

3. GitHub bounties & Algora START HERE

Why it fits: Open-source projects and tech startups attach cash ($50–$500 typical) to specific GitHub issues.

Why it builds seniority: You submit real PRs, take code review from maintainers, and build a public commit history anyone can verify.

Where: Algora.io, Opire, BountyHub, and GitHub search `label:"bounty"`. BountySource is defunct — do not use it.

4. Wellfound — Contract / gig filter START HERE

Filter Part-Time, Freelance, Contract, and intern-to-junior roles. Pitch 10–15 hours/week of API work, bug fixes, or Docker — not “hire me as senior full-stack.”

5. Contra micro-services START HERE

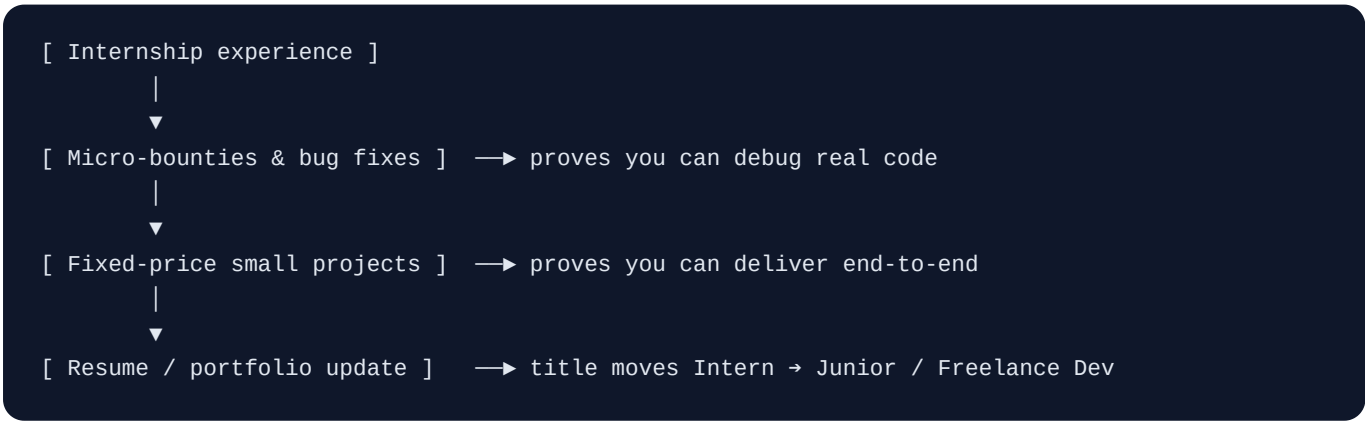
No bid fees, no commission. Showcase specific offers:

- “I will build a responsive React / Next.js landing page”
- “I will design and deploy a REST API with .NET or Laravel”
- “I will containerize your app with Docker Compose”

Bonus: Catchafire GOOD FIT

Volunteer or small-stipend tech projects for non-profits. Pay is low, but 2–3 finished end-to-end projects give client references you can list as **Freelance Software Engineer** instead of only Intern.

4. Practical strategy to upgrade seniority



Offer micro-services with clear scope

Do not bid on “Build a full web application.” Offer tight tasks:

- Fix CORS, database connection, or authentication issues in an API
- Convert a Figma design into responsive React or Jetpack Compose components
- Containerize a local project with Docker Compose

Frame the work as independent engineering

On LinkedIn and CV, group gigs under one title:

> **Title: Independent Software Contractor / Freelance Developer**
>
> Bullets focus on production impact, not tools: “Built and deployed REST APIs for local clients.” “Optimized database queries.” “Integrated third-party authentication.” “Fixed auth and CORS issues in existing codebases.”

5. GitHub bounties beyond Algora

Algora is visible, not unique. Several boards attach money to GitHub issues or similar micro-tasks.

Dedicated GitHub issue bounty platforms

Platform	How it works	Best for	Status
Opire `opire.dev`	Maintainer attaches cash with a bot command. You claim, PR, get paid on merge (Stripe).	Web, API fixes, general OSS. Low barrier.	START HERE
BountyHub `bountyhub.dev`	Paste a GitHub issue URL to fund or solve. Crowdfunded bounties. Stripe/PayPal, 120+ countries.	When you need a payout country that Stripe supports.	START HERE
IssueHunt `issuehunt.io`	Older GitHub bounty site. Funders attach money to repo issues.	Check the GitHub issue is still open before coding — listings can go stale.	LATER
Algora `algora.io`	Bounties on issues; also used by companies to hire from OSS contributors.	Search GitHub `label:"💎 Bounty"`	START HERE
Gitpay `gitpay.org`	OSS task marketplace tied to git workflows. Small features/bugs with dollar amounts.	Small listed tasks	GOOD FIT
BountySource	Historic aggregator for desktop/Linux app bounties.	—	INACTIVE bankrupt / site down

Web3 & crypto code bounties (you do not need smart contracts)

Superteam Earn START HERE — earn.superteam.fun

Full-stack, backend (Node / .NET / Python), frontend (React / Next.js), mobile. Companies post fixed tasks: API integrations, UI components. Typical $100–$2,500+. Paid in USDC (convert via a normal exchange). No developer platform fee.

Gitcoin GOOD FIT — gitcoin.co

OSS tools, docs, UI, infrastructure. Grants and issue bounties funded by DAOs and foundations.

Security vs feature work

Feature / code bounties (your path)

Fix bugs, write features, submit PRs.

Algora · Opire · IssueHunt · BountyHub · Superteam · GitHub search

Security / bug bounties (later)

Find vulnerabilities, file reports. Not intern-friendly as a first income plan.

MSRC · HackerOne · Bugcrowd · Huntr (now AI challenges, OSS program sunset)

> **Huntr is no longer a general OSS patch board**
>
> Huntr's traditional open-source vulnerability program stopped new submissions mid-2026 and pivoted to AI security challenges. Do not plan Laravel/.NET intern income there. Microsoft .NET / ASP.NET Core bounties are security-only (often $1,250–$40,000) via MSRC — not "add a feature" work.

Search GitHub directly

Many companies never list on a third-party board. Use:

```
is:issue is:open label:bounty
label:"help wanted" "bounty"
label:"paid"
label:"💎 Bounty"

is:issue is:open label:bounty "laravel"
is:issue is:open label:bounty "dotnet"
is:issue is:open label:bounty "react"
is:issue is:open label:bounty "vscode-extension"
is:issue is:open label:bounty "github action"
```

Beginner rule: Before coding, open the repo's Pull Requests tab. If maintainers are not merging community PRs, walk away — your work will sit unpaid.

6. Where you should try first

Match the board to payout style and to a .NET / Laravel / React / Next.js / Compose stack.

Order	Place	Why try it	Your target tasks
1	Opire + GitHub `label:bounty`	No interview. Payment on merge. Public seniority.	Laravel tests, .NET API bugs, React UI, Docker files
2	BountyHub	Stripe/PayPal, crowdfunded issues, 120+ countries	Same as above; check no open competing PR

Order	Place	Why try it	Your target tasks
3	Superteam Earn	Higher $ on React/Next and API work; no Solidity required	Frontend pages, REST adapters, Mini App UI
4	PeoplePerHour Hourlies + Contra	Packaged services, EU clients, 0% on Contra	Auth fix, Figma→React, Docker Compose
5	Wellfound contract filter	Startups need 10–15h/week executors	Short paid trial, then weekly retainer
—	Replit Bounties	Used to be $50–$300 bot/web gigs	**CLOSED SEPT 2025** — they pointed users to Contra

How to win the first bounty

1. **Check activity first.** Recent merges within days, not months.
2. **Comment before coding.** Example: “I’d like to take this. I plan to update the API controller, refactor the service layer, and add unit tests.”
3. **Skip crowded issues.** If 8 PRs already exist, pick another.
4. **Ship tests + README.** Maintainers merge the PR that is easy to trust.

7. Microsoft, Discord, and other open-source apps

Yes — but feature bounties and security bounties are different programs.

Microsoft

- **.NET & ASP.NET Core Bounty (MSRC):** Supported RTM versions, related GitHub Actions, docs samples. Payouts often $1,250–$40,000. This is vulnerability research, not intern feature work.
- **Microsoft OSS vulnerability bounties:** Select Microsoft-owned GitHub repos, up to about $15,000.
- There is no Algora-style “add this endpoint” board for Microsoft product features.

Discord bots & apps

Discord has no central bounty board. Work lives in community hubs:

- **Developer Discord servers** with `#jobs-and-gigs` / `#bounties`: The Coding Den, Discord API, Discord.js, Discord.Net. Typical $50–$300 for bots, webhooks, host migrations.
- **Replit Bounties:** used to be the main Discord-bot gig board — **shut down September 2025**. Use Contra + those Discord job channels instead.
- Open-source Discord-like projects (Revolt, Matrix/Element) sometimes fund issues via Opire/IssueHunt.

Skills: Node (discord.js), C# (Discord.Net), Python (discord.py), SQLite/PostgreSQL, Docker.

8. VS Code, Telegram, GitHub Apps

Ecosystem	Where	Ideal stack	What to search / build
VS Code extensions	Opire / BountyHub / GitHub issues	TypeScript, VS Code API, Webviews, LSP	`is:issue label:bounty "vscode-extension"`

Ecosystem	Where	Ideal stack	What to search / build
Telegram Mini Apps & bots	Superteam Earn, TON contests, tg.dev contests	React/Next, Node, Laravel, C#	Mini App UI, bot payments, telegraf/grammy. Official bug bounty: security@telegram.org ($100–$10,000, security not features).
Discord	Dev Discord #jobs, Contra	Node, C#, Python, Docker	Moderation bots, ticketing, webhooks
GitHub Actions & Apps	GitHub issue search	TypeScript, Go, Docker	`label:bounty "github action"` · `label:bounty "bot"`

9. Other ecosystems

Ecosystem	Platform / search	Best stack
Laravel / PHP packages, Filament, tests	GitHub `label:bounty laravel`, Opire, Coolify issues	PHP, Laravel, MySQL
WordPress / WooCommerce	GitHub bounty labels; Codeable is expert-only	PHP — skip Codeable until you are a WP specialist
Strapi / Directus	Repo issues + Opire	JS/TS, REST/GraphQL hooks
Chrome / Firefox extensions	`label:bounty "chrome extension"`, Contra, Wellfound	TypeScript, Manifest V3
elementary OS / KDE / GNOME	bounty.elementary.io, community funds	C++, Rust, Vala, GTK — only if you already know desktop stacks
AsyncAPI	Quarterly bounty rounds ~$100–$500	API specs, SDK/CLI generators
FinMind & open-data APIs	GitHub bounties ~$50–$1,000	Connectors, ORM adapters
AI / MCP servers	`label:bounty "mcp"`	Python, Node, C# / .NET

10. Consider your stack — where to start

For a backend-heavy full-stack mix of **.NET / C#**, **PHP / Laravel**, **React / Next.js / TypeScript**, and **Kotlin / Jetpack Compose**, you do not need generic bidding. Start in this order.

Phase 1 — high-probability micro-gigs

1. **GitHub + Opire / BountyHub (today).** Search `laravel`, `dotnet`, `react`. Comment, then PR with tests.
2. **Superteam Earn (today).** Frontend / integration tasks $100–$500. Submit a live Next.js or API demo. Replit is gone — do not look for it.
3. **PeoplePerHour Hourlies + Contra (this week).** Three packaged offers (see below).

Phase 2 — open-source seniority

Target issues about API routes, PHPUnit / xUnit coverage, DI/ORM bugs, Docker. Never write code until a maintainer confirms the bounty is live.

Phase 3 — client contracts

Wellfound: “I specialize in .NET and Laravel REST APIs and React frontends. I can do 10–15 hours/week of endpoints, bug fixes, or Docker Compose.”

Contra services to publish:

1. Production-ready REST API in Laravel or ASP.NET Core with JWT
2. Figma → responsive React / Next.js
3. Docker Compose for local app + database

> **Coolify is a strong Laravel match**
>
> coollabsio/coolify often has PHP/Laravel bounties in a beginner-accessible range. Filter for issues with few competing PRs.

11. Do you pay? Is there an interview?

> **You never pay to work**
>
> Legit boards never ask for money to get hired, unlock payouts, buy equipment, or “verify” an account. Processing fees, crypto deposits, and setup fees = scam.

	Apply / submit	When you get paid	Interview?
Opire, BountyHub, GitHub issues	Free	You keep the bounty; funder is charged	None. The code review is the interview.
Superteam Earn	Free	Full listed USDC, no developer cut	None. Owner picks the best submitted demo.
Contra, Guru, PeoplePerHour	Free to apply	Platform or card fees after you earn	Sometimes a short chat after they like a sample.
Wellfound / Contra contracts	Free	Agreed rate	15–30 min Discord/Meet: stack check + paid trial. Not an HR loop.

12. What prices should you take as a beginner?

Charge **fixed-price micro-gigs**, not “I will google for $8/hr.” Fixed scope removes client fear and hides the learning time.

Scope	Examples	Beginner price	Time
API & backend fixes (.NET / Laravel)	1–2 endpoints, CORS/auth, migrations	$30 – $80	2–4 hours
Full small API / microservice	JWT, models, validation, Postman	$120 – $250	1–2 days
Frontend UI (React / Next.js)	Figma section → Tailwind	$50 – $120	3–6 hours
Android UI (Jetpack Compose)	1–2 screens, ViewModel, Material 3	$60 – $150	4–8 hours

Scope	Examples	Beginner price	Time
Docker / local devops	compose for app + DB + Nginx	$30 – $60	1–2 hours
Live debug (Codementor, later)	Call to unstick a beginner	$15 – $25 / 15 min	15–30 min

> **Hourly if they insist**
>
> Start at **$15–$25/hr**. After 3–5 successful gigs, raise to **$25–$35/hr**. Never drop price without cutting scope: “$80 if we skip custom roles and ship core CRUD only.” Factor 2–5% for Stripe/PayPal/USDC conversion.

Take two or three $30–$50 bug fixes first. The review/PR merge is worth more than the $30.

13. Why is this not as famous as Upwork — is it legit?

Yes. These are real companies and real maintainer payouts. Opire, Superteam, Algora, Contra, PeoplePerHour, Wellfound, and Hubstaff are not “secret intern scams.” They are smaller because they do not buy Super Bowl ads.

Upwork / Fiverr model

- General non-technical clients
- Bidding wars and long proposals
- HR-style interviews and resumes
- High platform commission
- Massive marketing budget

Bounty / micro-gig model

- Developer-to-developer (or founder-dev)
- Code-first: PRs, GitHub, live demos
- Usually no interview
- Zero-to-low commission for you
- Quiet, niche, less spam

- **They solve a technical need, not an HR need.** The buyer wants a bug fixed this week, not a two-week interview loop.
- **Payout is tied to code.** Submit → tests/review pass → money releases. Fewer “did you work enough hours?” fights.
- **Different money model.** Superteam is funded to attract builders. Opire/BountyHub charge the funder. Upwork charges both sides and funds ads with that.
- **Advantage for an intern:** a $50 Upwork job gets 50 spam proposals. A GitHub bounty often has 2–3 people who can actually open a clean PR.

14. Day-1 checklist & scam red flags

Today

- Create Opire + Superteam Earn + GitHub bounty search bookmarks
- Find *one* open issue in Laravel, .NET, or React with an active maintainer
- Comment to claim it; do not ghost after commenting

Tomorrow

- Submit or continue that PR with tests
- Pick one Superteam frontend/integration task and start a live demo

This week

- Contra profile with 2–3 fixed micro-services and prices from Section 12
- PeoplePerHour Hourlie + Hubstaff Talent profile at $15–$25/hr
- Wellfound: 10 contract / part-time applications, stack-specific pitch
- Ask internship mentors for a junior conversion, referral, or LinkedIn recommendation

> **Walk away immediately if they ask for**
>
> Upfront payment for equipment, test software, or “security clearance.” Crypto deposits before they pay you. Moving to personal Telegram/WhatsApp before there is a platform contract. A site A1 Net Protect (or any antivirus/DNS filter) flags as malware — that is not a freelance board.

This guide excludes Upwork and Fiverr on purpose. Toptal, Braintrust, and Arc.dev are listed because they are real high-end networks — they are not intern starting points. Prefer public PRs, Hourlies, Contra packaged services, and Wellfound contracts until you have reviews and a junior title.